

OnePlus Nord 4

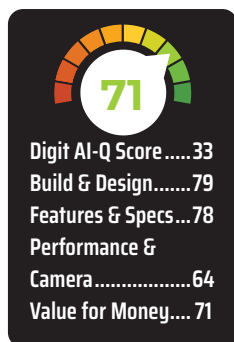
Metallic marvel

The OnePlus Nord portfolio receives its annual refresh with the launch of the new OnePlus Nord 4, bringing a touch of nostalgia. Tugging at the heartstrings of OG tech lovers, the OnePlus Nord 4 boasts an all-metal unibody design that harks back to fan-favourite smartphones of the past, such as the beloved HTC One M8 and OnePlus' own OnePlus 3T. Metal back phones fell out of favour because ensuring that the antennae required for faster 5G connectivity weren't blocked is significantly harder. However, OnePlus has addressed this challenge with the Nord 4, bringing all-metal phones back into the present-day 5G era. So, we no longer have to look back on them fondly; they are now a reality.

Under its metallic exterior is a phone with solid hardware, packing high-end specifications like the Snapdragon 7+ Gen 3 chipset, a 1.5K AMOLED screen, a large 5,500 mAh battery, and much more. However, the competition in this price segment is cutthroat, with phones like the Realme GT 6T, POCO F6, and Motorola Edge 50 Pro, all vying for the top spot too. Let's see how this metallic marvel fares against these phones in our detailed review.

BUILD AND DESIGN

Available in three unique colour variants, the OnePlus Nord 4 looks sublime across the board. I got the Mercurial Silver colour variant for review. There's a subtle Obsidian Midnight (Black) colour, and what I assume would be a crowd favourite, an Oasis Green dual-tone colour variant. The Mercurial Silver colour variant I got is a looker as well with its sheet metal look. The lower two-thirds of the rear panel looks textured but it's actually smooth to the touch, adding to the appeal.



A single metal sheet runs across the back and the frame of the phone, offering a seamless look. However, a thin sheet of glass is placed on the upper third of the phone's rear panel, breaking up the monotony. Within this sheet of glass, you've got two cameras placed horizontally (much like Pixel phones) and a dual LED flash.

The OnePlus Nord 4 also features the iconic alert slider on the left side of the frame, which is extremely satisfying to use. The buttons are nice and tactile, and the in-display fingerprint sensor is accurate and fast. There are other niceties too such as an IR blaster and a dual stereo speaker setup. The phone is rated IP65, meaning it is fully dustproof and can withstand splashes of water without being damaged.

The in-hand feel of the phone is premium, albeit slightly slippery due to the smooth metal texture. Its contours curve perfectly against your palm which makes it very comfortable to hold over longer

periods. All in all, this is a svelte, classy design, one that OnePlus should continue using, maybe even on its flagship phones.

DISPLAY

The OnePlus Nord 4 features an expansive 6.74-inch flat AMOLED ProXDR display with 1.5K resolution and a 120 Hz refresh rate. The bezels surrounding the screen are super slim, and nearly even all the way around. The display also supports HDR10+ and Widevine L1; however, HDR support hasn't made its way over to Netflix and Prime Video so far, which is disappointing. The ProXDR AMOLED display is sharp and vivid, making the Nord 4 an excellent companion for content consumption. The colours are also very close to accurate right out of the box.

The screen is very bright too. It boasts a peak brightness of 2,150 nits that's only applicable on some portions of the display when viewing HDR content. In HBM, we got a reading of 1,081 nits under bright sunlight, which should be more than enough for perfect legibility even on the sunniest days. Overall, this display is competent enough to go up against its competitors, but the Motorola Edge 50 Pro's display could look a tad more colour-accurate.

PERFORMANCE AND UI

Powered by the zippy Qualcomm Snapdragon 7+ Gen 3 processor, the OnePlus Nord 4 impresses with its performance chops. The day-to-day usage experience is excellent with smooth animations and speedy operations, with apps such as WhatsApp, Instagram, YouTube, Google Maps, and others working flawlessly.

The phone is kitted with 8 or 12 GB of LPDDR5X RAM and 128 or 256 GB internal storage. The 128 GB variant supports UFS 3.1 while the more expensive 256 GB unit supports the latest UFS 4.0. The segmentation irks me, and I think OnePlus shouldn't have launched a 128 GB variant at this price at all; it is too low for users' growing storage needs. However, multitasking and data transfer speeds were fantastic on my 12 + 256 GB unit.

Now, while the phone performs very well in real-world usage, its benchmark scores indicate some intentional throt-